



The APS Data Analysis Protocol

The APS Data Analysis Protocol is designed to be used with an entire school staff, a school leadership team, a district department team, a group of teachers, or by one individual. Through its five steps, participants will:

- Use data that is valid (does the data accurately measure what it is intended to) and reliable (would the data produce the same answer if it was used again)
- Challenge their viewpoints, beliefs, and assumptions about the data
- Move from identifying symptoms (what you see or experience) to possible causes (the mechanisms or conditions that generate those symptoms)
- Define next steps and implement a formal process to track and evaluate progress

Before beginning, the facilitator will ensure that all data reports needed for the discussion are available and that [The APS Data Analysis Graphic Organizer](#) has been started.

The APS Data Analysis Protocol is designed to be accomplished in 45 minutes or less. However, the time can be expanded or contracted to fit the needs of an individual or team.

Step 1 — Context and Focus (5 minutes)

In this step the facilitator provides an overview of the session's focus and introduces **The APS Data Analysis Protocol** and **The APS Data Analysis Graphic Organizer** that will be used for the session.

- It is critical to maintain a single focus per session (e.g., Grade 1 Middle-of-Year (MOY) Amira reading proficiency rates, Grade 6 MOY i-Ready math proficiency rates etc.).
- To maximize the group's collective insight, teams may be assigned a specific student demographic (e.g., English Learners, etc.) within the focus area.

Tips & Tricks

- *The facilitator should complete the APS Data Analysis Graphic Organizer before leading the protocol with a team.*
- *Clearly state the purpose of the protocol and identify the specific data source being evaluated.*

Step 2 — Predictions (10 minutes)

This step takes place before viewing the data. Use this time to activate prior knowledge, surface assumptions, and make predictions. By suspending judgment, you create a readiness to objectively examine and discuss the data. Listen to and honor all assumptions as building blocks for new learning.

- Participants fill out the Predictions column in [The Data Analysis Graphic Organizer](#) (5 minutes).
- Predictions are reported out to the group (5 minutes).

Personal/Small Group Think Time

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Produced by the Albuquerque Public Schools, Strategic Analysis & Program Research (SAPR) Department on December 18, 2025. Adopted from Teacher Development Group, 2002, Nancy Love, author of "Using Data/Getting Results," 2002, and Kathryn P. Boudett, Elizabeth A. City, and Richard J. Murnane, authors of "Data Wise: A Step-by-Step Guide to Using Assessment Results to Improve Teaching and Learning", 2005.

Privately reflect and record your preliminary thoughts. One or more of the following thought-starters may be helpful:

- I assume...
- I predict...
- I wonder...
- Some possibilities for learning that this data may present are...

Tips & Tricks

- *Encourage participants to refrain from viewing the data prior to this step.*
- *This step prompts participants to think critically about the data and surface potential biases. When group members share predictions, the facilitator should provide immediate feedback if a participant is not following the protocol.*
- *If a participant says, "I predict X because of Y," remind the group that Steps 2 and 3 are for observations only and should not include "because" statements or causal explanations.*

Step 3 — Observations (10 minutes)

This step takes place once the facilitator makes the data available. In this step you will engage with the actual data. It is important to note only the facts that you can observe in the data. Conjectures, explanations, conclusions, and inferences are off-limits. You can make statements about quantities (e.g., over half the students...) and patterns that you see in the data.

- Participants analyze the data for patterns, trends, relationships, and surprises as they fill out the Observations column in [The Data Analysis Graphic Organizer](#) (5 minutes).
- Observations are reported out to the group (5 minutes).

Personal/Small Group Think Time

Study the data privately and record several of your observations. One or more of the following thought-starters may be helpful:

- I observe that...
- Some patterns/trends/relationships that I notice are...
- I am surprised to see that...

Tips & Tricks

- *Remember, just the facts. Avoid interpretive or causal language such as "because," "therefore," "it seems," or "however."*
- *Encourage participants to provide observations that lead to questions that can be explored in Steps 4 and 5.*
 - ◆ *Example: Identifying that "proficiency rates for Group A are higher this year than last year" is more actionable than simply stating "the current proficiency rate is 25%."*
- *Helpful Definitions*
 - ◆ *Trends - change of data over time; tendency over time*
 - ◆ *Patterns - multiple occurrences of a characteristic or trait*
 - ◆ *Relationships - connections between two or more measures; extent to which two or more variables fluctuate together (negative or positive)*

Step 4 — Inferences and Implications (10 minutes)

In this step you will generate explanations for your Step 3 Observations and identify additional data that may be needed to confirm/contradict your explanations. As you work through this step, draw on your experience and expertise as you generate ideas. The inferences and implications identified in this step will be used to drive action in Step 5.

- Participants fill out the Inferences and Implications column in [The Data Analysis Graphic Organizer](#) (5 minutes).
- Predications are reported out to the group (5 minutes).

Personal/Small Group Think Time

Reflect privately using one or more of the following thought starters to prompt your thinking:

- I believe the data suggests... because...
- Additional data that would help me verify/confirm my explanations is...

Tips & Tricks

- *You may continue focusing on your specific student group or expand your thinking to include all observations shared by the team.*
- *To identify root causes, consider current actions or lack of action. It may be helpful to ask: "What are we currently doing—or not doing—that might be contributing to these results?"*

Step 5 — Next Steps (10 minutes)

In this step you will propose solutions/responses to address Inferences and Implications documented in Step 4 and identify data needed to monitor implementation of your solutions/responses.

- All participants discuss next steps and the facilitator fills out the [The APS Data Analysis Next Steps Weekly Tracker](#).

Group Discussion

Use one or more of the following thought starters to prompt your thinking:

- The following are appropriate solutions/responses that address needs observed in the data...
- What additional data will be collected on a weekly basis that will help guide implementation of the solutions/responses and determine if they are working...

Tips & Tricks

- *The Next Steps Weekly Tracker is flexible. You can modify the data-tracking cadence (e.g., bi-weekly or monthly) to better align with your specific solution and available data.*
- *The primary objective is to exit the discussion with a concrete action plan that can be monitored and measured at regular intervals.*

The APS Data Analysis Graphic Organizer

This document is designed to help organize the data analysis process, record what was discussed during steps 2-3, and to clearly establish next steps. Next steps and proposed actions can be documented with the Next Steps Weekly Tracker.

Step 1 Context and Focus		
Focus of Session:		Grade Level(s):
Data Source(s):		Time Period(s):
		Student Group(s):
Step 2 Predictions	Step 3 Observations	Step 4 Inferences and Implications
→ I assume... → I predict... → I wonder... → Some possibilities for learning that this data may present are...	→ I observe that... → Some patterns/trends/relationships that I notice are... → I am surprised to see that...	→ I believe the data suggests... because... → Additional data that would help me verify/confirm my explanations is...
Person/Group 1: • Person/Group 2: • Person/Group 3: • Person/Group 4: • Person/Group 5: •	Person/Group 1: • Person/Group 2: • Person/Group 3: • Person/Group 4: • Person/Group 5: •	Person/Group 1: • Person/Group 2: • Person/Group 3: • Person/Group 4: • Person/Group 5: •

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The **APS** Data Analysis Next Steps Weekly Tracker

Step 5 Next Steps

Reason for Action:

Specific Action that will Implemented:

Measurement that will be Recorded on a Weekly Basis to Track Implementation:

Staff Names	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
1.				
2.				
3.				
4.				
5.				
6.				
7.				
8.				
9.				
10.				